

**THE
ANXIOUS-AVOIDANT
TRAP**



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CHAPTER ONE

The Diagnosis

The Mirror

"The chase doesn't begin when you send a message. It begins the moment your nervous system mistakes uncertainty for danger."

The Bodily Shift: Uncertainty → Urgency

The chase doesn't start in your sent texts—it starts in your body.

The moment a reply slows down or a "Read" receipt sits unanswered, your nervous system interprets a blank screen as a threat.

Your body reacts long before your mind creates a story.

The Somatic Flare

You may notice:

- Sudden warmth in your chest
- Tightness in your jaw
- Shallow breathing
- A hollow feeling in your stomach
- Restlessness that makes sitting still almost impossible

These sensations aren't random.

They're your nervous system sounding an alarm.

The Dopamine Loop

Your phone becomes a slot machine.

Every notification promises relief.

Every silence creates another pull to check again.

You're no longer chasing connection.

You're chasing temporary relief from anxiety.

Unfortunately...

Relief lasts only a few moments before the cycle begins again.

The Mechanics of the Dynamic

Anxious and avoidant attachment styles often become trapped together because both nervous systems are reacting to old survival patterns.

The Chaser (Anxious)

The anxious nervous system is wired to notice distance.

It constantly scans for:

- Delayed replies
- Changes in tone
- Shorter messages
- Emotional shifts
- Signs of abandonment

Silence is interpreted as danger.

The response becomes:

- texting more
- explaining more
- trying harder
- fixing the relationship immediately

The goal is simple:

Restore safety.

The Runner (Avoidant)

The avoidant nervous system experiences closeness differently.

Too much emotional intensity can feel overwhelming.

Instead of comfort, intimacy may trigger:

- pressure
- suffocation
- loss of independence
- fear of emotional responsibility

The response becomes distance.

Not always because love is absent—

but because the nervous system wants space to regulate itself.

The Trap

The Runner pulls away.

↓

Your nervous system panics.

↓

You chase harder.

↓

Your pursuit increases their sense of pressure.

↓

They pull away even further.

↓

Your anxiety grows stronger.

The cycle repeats.

Your nervous system becomes the battery powering the entire relationship dynamic.

CHAPTER TWO

The Uncomfortable Truth

The Shift

"Not every intense feeling is love. Sometimes it's simply an activated nervous system searching for relief."

Anxiety Is Not Passion

When uncertainty appears...

your brain immediately begins searching for meaning.

It whispers:

"If I feel this strongly...they must be the one."

But intensity isn't evidence.

It's activation.

The stronger the uncertainty...

the stronger the emotional reaction becomes.

The Reality

The relief you feel after receiving a text isn't proof of compatibility.

It's proof that anxiety temporarily disappeared.

Many people unknowingly confuse:

Relief → Safety

Intensity → Love

Anxiety → Passion

Healthy love rarely feels like constant panic.

It feels consistent.

Predictable.

Calm.

Inside the Runner's Mind

Understanding avoidance doesn't mean excusing harmful behavior.

It simply explains why chasing rarely works.

When someone with avoidant tendencies feels emotionally overwhelmed...

they often experience:

Check-ins

as emotional demands.

Requests for reassurance

as pressure.

Constant explanations

as increasing emotional intensity.

The more urgently someone pursues them...

the stronger their nervous system pushes them toward distance.

The Shift

Stop treating another person's nervous system like a puzzle you must solve.

You cannot reason someone out of a biological stress response.

The harder you chase...

the faster they run.

CHAPTER THREE

The Circuit Breaker

The Action Plan

"Healing begins the moment you interrupt the automatic reaction."

Step One

Pause & Locate

The instant you feel the urge to send another message...

Pause.

Do not move your thumb.

Take one slow breath.

Ask yourself:

"Where do I feel this inside my body?"

Maybe it's:

- tightness in your chest
- pressure in your throat
- shaking hands
- tension in your stomach

Place your hand over that area.

Then quietly say:

"This is an urgency signal. My nervous system is activated by uncertainty. I am not in physical danger."

Naming the experience separates you from it.

Step Two

The 20-Minute Buffer

Your brain will insist:

"I need to fix this right now."

Don't argue with it.

Delay it.

Set a timer for **20 minutes**.

During those 20 minutes:

- Don't text.
- Don't read old messages.
- Don't check their profile.
- Don't look for clues.

Instead:

- walk outside
- stretch
- wash dishes
- drink cold water
- breathe slowly

Let your nervous system finish the stress response naturally.

Step Three

Shift the Spotlight

When the timer ends...

your mind will probably want to investigate again.

Instead...

ask yourself:

"What do I need right now to feel safe inside myself?"

Maybe you need:

- rest
- food
- movement
- conversation with a trusted friend
- quiet

Whatever the answer...

give it to yourself first.

Then remind yourself:

"My worth is not measured by someone else's response time."

FINAL REFLECTION

Every time you resist the urge to chase...

you teach your nervous system something new.

You prove that uncertainty is uncomfortable—

not dangerous.

Real healing isn't about making someone text you back.

It's about becoming emotionally safe without needing immediate reassurance.

Over time...

the urgency becomes quieter.

The panic loses its grip.

And the version of you that once begged for certainty begins to trust themselves instead.

Remember

You don't heal by getting the text.

You heal by no longer needing the text to feel okay.